

Appendix: Professional Word Banks

for Early Childhood Observation Documentation

Having Tough Conversations with Families of Children Who Require Additional Support

How to use this appendix: These word banks provide professionally framed, objective language to support accurate observation and documentation. Choose words that describe what you directly see or hear. Avoid words that label, judge, or diagnose. When in doubt, ask: 'Could I describe exactly what I observed that led me to choose this word?' If yes — it belongs in your notes.

This appendix includes word banks for:

1. Observable Behaviors & Actions
2. Social-Emotional Development
3. Communication & Language
4. Sensory Inputs (What the Environment Offers)
5. Sensory Responses & Outputs (How the Child Responds)
6. Attention & Learning
7. Physical & Motor Development
8. Transition & Routine Responses
9. Peer Interaction
10. Adult Interaction & Response
11. Emotional Expression
12. Strengths & Positive Descriptors
13. Strategies & Supports
14. Documentation Phrases & Sentence Starters

1. Observable Behaviors & Actions

Use these verbs and phrases to describe what you directly see a child doing.

These action words describe visible, observable behaviors without interpreting motive or assigning labels. Pair them with specifics: who, when, where, how long, how often.

Movement & Physical Actions		
ran toward	walked away from	climbed onto
sat beside	stood near	moved to the edge of
lay on the floor	reached for	pointed to
pushed away	pulled toward	turned away from
covered with hands	rocked back and forth	jumped up and down
spun in place	flapped hands	tapped repeatedly
rolled on the floor	crouched down	leaned against
paced back and forth	dropped to the ground	picked up
carried	placed down gently	threw onto

Vocal & Communication Actions		
said (exact words)	repeated	called out
asked for	pointed and vocalized	made sounds such as
cried	laughed	hummed
sang	whispered	shouted
echoed what was said	did not respond verbally	responded after a pause of
used gestures to indicate	shook head yes/no	nodded
waved	made eye contact	looked away when spoken to
looked toward the speaker		

Task & Activity Actions		
picked up materials	put down materials	completed the task
stopped after step one	attempted three times	left the activity after
returned to the activity	watched before joining	joined after two minutes
requested help by	worked independently for	required one-to-one support to
completed with a visual cue	finished with verbal prompting	did not attempt
chose the same material each time	switched materials frequently	

Social Actions		
played beside	played with	approached a peer
moved away from a peer	watched peers from a distance	offered a toy to
took a toy from	waited for a turn	did not wait for a turn
entered a peer's play	exited the group	smiled at
hugged	made a facial expression such as	initiated conversation by saying
responded to a peer by		

2. Social-Emotional Development

Objective language for documenting emotional responses, self-regulation, and relationships.

Describe what the child does during emotional moments — not what you think the child feels or intends. Note duration, triggers, and what helped.

Emotion Expression — Observable Signs		
tears ran down face	cried audibly for ____ minutes	smiled broadly
laughed aloud	giggled	frowned
furrowed brow	tightened jaw	clenched fists
crossed arms	turned body away	covered face with hands
hid under furniture	jumped with excitement	clapped hands
stomped feet	screamed	whimpered
held breath briefly	took a slow breath	

Self-Regulation Behaviors		
took three deep breaths	walked to the calm-down corner	requested a break
used a fidget tool	sat quietly for ____ seconds before responding	used words to express frustration
identified the feeling by name	used a visual support to calm	returned to activity within ____ minutes
needed adult co-regulation for ____ minutes	calmed with verbal support	calmed with physical proximity of an adult
calmed with preferred object	calmed after movement break	calmed independently

Transition Between Emotional States		
moved from distress to calm within ____ minutes	recovered after adult acknowledged the feeling	re-engaged with activity after ____
needed ____ minutes before rejoining the group	accepted comfort from the adult	pushed comfort away initially, then accepted
self-initiated return to activity	required redirection ____ times before re-engaging	

Relationships & Attachment Behaviors		
sought adult proximity during ____	checked in visually with the adult every ____	greeted the adult by name
waved goodbye at departure	expressed reluctance to separate at drop-off	separated from caregiver within ____ minutes

initiated physical affection with the adult	responded warmly to adult greetings	showed preference for a specific adult
sought adult help when frustrated		

3. Communication & Language

Objective terms for documenting how a child communicates — expressively and receptively.

Note the child's primary communication mode, specific examples, and the context. Document the child's approximate vocabulary, use of sentences, and how others respond.

Expressive Language — What the Child Produces		
used single words	used two-word combinations	used short sentences (3–4 words)
used complete sentences	used gestures only	used pointing to indicate needs
used vocalizations without words	approximated words (e.g., said '___' for '___')	echoed adult speech (immediate echolalia)
repeated phrases from books or videos	asked questions using 'what' 'where' 'why'	named objects
described actions	shared experiences verbally	communicated using a device or picture symbols
used sign language	combined words and gestures	initiated conversation
responded to conversational partner		

Receptive Language — How the Child Understands		
followed a one-step direction	followed a two-step direction	followed a three-step direction with visual support
responded to their name	responded to name after ___ attempts	identified objects when named
pointed to pictures when named	understood positional concepts (on, under, beside)	followed classroom routines without verbal prompting
required visual or gestural cue to follow direction	did not respond to verbal direction alone	looked toward sound or voice
understood simple questions		

Fluency & Articulation (Describe, Do Not Diagnose)		
speech was understood by familiar adults	speech was understood by unfamiliar adults	speech required clarification ___ times during observation
repeated initial sounds or syllables	paused frequently before responding	spoke in a soft voice
spoke very loudly in all settings	varied volume and tone	spoke at a very fast rate

spoke at a very slow rate		
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Pragmatics — Social Use of Language		
maintained eye contact during conversation	took conversational turns	stayed on topic for ____ turns
shifted topics abruptly	greeted peers or adults	used language to request, comment, and protest
narrated own play aloud	asked for help verbally	responded to peer initiations
initiated interactions with peers		

4. Sensory Inputs (What the Environment Offers)

Use these terms to describe the sensory qualities present in the environment during observation.

When documenting sensory-related observations, first describe the environment accurately — what sights, sounds, textures, and movement demands were present. Then separately describe how the child responded (see Section 5). This helps identify patterns and plan supports.

Auditory Inputs — Sounds in the Environment

loud group noise	music playing at high volume	sudden loud sounds (e.g., alarm, door slamming)
background noise (fans, HVAC, hallway)	multiple voices speaking at once	high-pitched sounds
low-pitched sounds	rhythmic sounds	unpredictable sounds
quiet environment	near-silent setting	outdoor noise
echoing room acoustics	music with percussion	talking at close range

Tactile Inputs — Touch & Texture

wet or damp materials (water, paint, glue)	sticky textures (tape, stickers, slime)	soft textures (playdough, sand, fabric)
rough or scratchy textures	smooth hard surfaces	messy multi-texture materials
light touch from peers or adults	firm pressure (hugs, squeezes)	clothing with tags or seams
bare feet on different floor surfaces	food textures (mushy, crunchy, wet, dry)	temperature variation (warm, cold)

Visual Inputs — What the Child Sees

bright overhead fluorescent lighting	natural sunlight through windows	dim lighting
flickering light sources	visually busy wall displays	minimal visual décor
movement of peers or adults nearby	fast-moving objects or activities	screens or projected images
strong color contrasts	patterns or repetition in environment	

Proprioceptive & Vestibular Inputs — Movement & Body Position

heavy work activities (pushing, pulling, carrying)	climbing structures	swinging or rocking equipment
spinning activities	jumping or bouncing surfaces	crawling through tunnels or under furniture
carrying weighted items	sitting on unstable surface (wobble cushion)	standing or sitting on floor (no chair back support)
seated at a table with chair	movement-based transitions	long periods of required stillness

Olfactory & Gustatory Inputs – Smell & Taste		
strong food smells at mealtime	cleaning product scents	paint or art material odors
outdoor/nature smells	mixed food textures and flavors	familiar food items
unfamiliar or new food items	foods with strong flavors (sour, spicy, bitter)	

5. Sensory Responses & Outputs (How the Child Responds)

Objective language for describing how a child responds to sensory experiences.

These terms describe what you observe — not what it means. A child's response to sensory input can range from seeking more to actively avoiding. Document the specific response, its duration, and what helped. Never use 'sensory issues' or 'sensory problems' as a documentation term.

Reminder: Write 'During art time, Marcus pulled his hands away from the paint and said "yucky" four times' — not 'Marcus has sensory issues.' Your role is to describe what you observe.

Sensory Seeking Responses — The Child Appears to Want More Input

sought additional touch by rubbing materials on skin	requested to repeat the movement activity	chose to return to the sensory bin repeatedly
touched surfaces and materials frequently	put objects in mouth beyond typical age expectation	sought deep pressure by pressing against furniture or adults
jumped, spun, or rocked repeatedly during free choice	made loud sounds repeatedly in quiet settings	sought bright or moving visual stimulation
ran rather than walked in most contexts	frequently bumped into or leaned on peers	requested rough-and-tumble play
smelled objects before using or eating them		

Sensory Avoidance Responses — The Child Appears to Want Less Input

pulled hands away from material	covered ears with hands	turned head away from sound source
moved to the edge of the group	covered eyes	left the area when sound increased
pushed food away without tasting	gagged when near certain food textures	resisted transitioning between floor surfaces
removed clothing items (shoes, socks, tags)	avoided physical contact with peers	protested when touched unexpectedly
cried or became distressed when ____	closed mouth tightly when offered food	refused messy materials during art time
sat away from the group during sensory activities		

Neutral or Adaptive Responses – The Child Manages the Input Well		
engaged with the material for ____ minutes	participated with verbal encouragement	tolerated the input with adult proximity
requested a modification (e.g., gloves, tool)	returned to the activity after a short break	used a preferred tool to engage with material
self-selected a quieter area	asked for earmuffs/headphones during loud activity	used a visual schedule to prepare for sensory activity
calmed within ____ minutes after sensory experience	participated with a peer model present	

Physical Responses to Note (Describe, Do Not Diagnose)		
blinked repeatedly when ____	wrinkled nose when near ____	tensed shoulders when ____
stiffened body when touched	relaxed body when given deep pressure	became more alert after movement
became calmer after heavy work activity	yawned or appeared drowsy during ____	increased activity level after prolonged sitting
decreased activity level after movement break		

6. Attention & Learning

Objective terms for describing how a child engages, focuses, and approaches learning.

Focus on observable behavior — how long, how often, under what conditions. Avoid 'can't focus' or 'doesn't try.' Describe what you see.

Engagement & Focus — Describe Duration and Conditions		
sustained attention for ____ minutes during ____	looked at materials for ____ seconds before ____	maintained focus with adult seated nearby
maintained focus when visual distractions were reduced	maintained focus with preferred materials	disengaged after ____ minutes
required a refocus prompt every ____ minutes	re-engaged within ____ seconds of prompt	remained on task for entire ____ minute activity
shifted attention when a peer entered the area	looked up from task when noise increased	watched peers before beginning the task
glanced around the room frequently during ____		

Task Initiation & Completion		
began the task independently within ____ seconds	began the task after one verbal prompt	began the task after a visual or physical cue
required repeated prompting to begin	completed the task independently	completed ____ out of ____ steps independently
stopped at step ____ and required support to continue	did not complete the task during the allotted time	requested a break after ____ minutes
returned to task after break and completed it	transitioned to a new task when directed	persisted through difficulty before seeking help
asked for help after ____ attempts		

Learning Approaches — How the Child Engages		
tried multiple approaches before succeeding	watched a peer model before attempting	responded well to visual demonstrations
responded well to verbal step-by-step instructions	worked best in a small group of ____	worked best one-to-one with an adult
preferred to work independently	asked clarifying questions before starting	preferred hands-on or movement-based activities
showed interest in books and print materials	engaged most with open-ended creative activities	transferred a skill learned in one setting to another
required repeated practice across ____ days to master		

Memory & Retention (Observable Behaviors)		
recalled the routine without a visual schedule	required a visual schedule to navigate the routine	remembered the activity from the previous day
did not appear to recall previous instruction on ____	generalized the skill to a new adult	generalized the skill to a new setting
applied the skill consistently across ____ days	required a re-teach after a long weekend or break	

7. Physical & Motor Development

Observable language for gross motor, fine motor, and physical participation.

Document what the child can do and what level of support was needed. Describe rather than compare to peers. Never say 'can't' — describe what was observed instead.

Gross Motor — Large Movement		
walked on level surface independently	ran with coordination	ran with frequent stumbles or falls
climbed the ladder with two-hand support	climbed independently	jumped with both feet leaving the ground
jumped from a low step	hopped on one foot	walked up stairs alternating feet
walked up stairs with same foot leading	walked up stairs holding the railing	kicked a ball with dominant foot
threw a ball overhand	caught a large ball	balanced on one foot for ____ seconds
rode a balance bike or tricycle	navigated obstacles in the environment	walked on uneven surfaces with support

Fine Motor — Small Movement & Hand Use		
grasped objects using full hand	used pincer grasp (thumb and index finger)	held a crayon or marker with fist grip
held a writing tool with three-finger grip	transferred objects between hands	stacked ____ blocks before tower fell
completed a ____ piece puzzle independently	completed puzzle with adult hand-over-hand support	cut along a straight line
cut along a curved line	fastened a large button	zipped and unzipped a jacket
opened and closed a container independently	used scissors with both hands stabilizing	drew a recognizable shape
drew a figure with distinct parts	used a fork or spoon independently	opened a snack bag independently

Physical Participation in Routines		
removed shoes and placed in cubby independently	needed hand-over-hand support to remove shoes	washed hands with verbal prompting
washed hands independently	served food with a spoon independently	needed support to navigate the cafeteria line
carried a lunch tray with two hands	sat at table for duration of meal	required adapted seating to participate
used adapted utensil provided by family	moved between carpet and table independently	required a mobility device to navigate the classroom

8. Transition & Routine Responses

Language for documenting how a child moves through transitions and daily routines.

Transitions are often when challenging behaviors are most visible. Document the specific transition, the child's response, the level of support needed, and what helped.

Smooth Transitions – When Things Go Well

moved to the next activity independently	followed the transition signal without prompting	used the visual schedule to anticipate the next activity
acknowledged the 5-minute warning and adjusted	said goodbye to activity and moved on	arrived at the next setting within ____ seconds
joined the group at the next activity within ____	used transition object to move between settings	arrived at circle time and sat within ____ seconds

Challenging Transitions – Describe What You See

sat on the floor and did not move when given the signal	said 'no' and continued previous activity for ____ minutes	required one-to-one adult escort during the transition
cried for ____ minutes during/after the transition	ran in the opposite direction	dropped to the ground at the transition cue
hit or kicked when redirected	needed ____ verbal prompts to complete the transition	required a countdown or warning timer
remained upset for ____ minutes after reaching the next activity	transitioned with support from a preferred adult	transitioned after being offered a specific choice

Routine Participation

followed the morning arrival routine independently	required visual supports to follow the routine	completed clean-up independently
needed verbal prompts at each step of the routine	packed up belongings at dismissal independently	remembered the routine after a long break with support
initiated routine steps without prompting	completed hand-washing routine in correct sequence	

9. Peer Interaction

Objective terms for describing how a child relates to and interacts with other children.

Describe what you observe — not what you interpret about the child's social skills or intent.

Proximity & Awareness of Peers

played in the same area as peers without interaction	watched peers' play from a distance of ____	moved closer to peers over time
moved away when a peer approached	stayed at the edge of the group	sat within ____ feet of peers during circle time
chose to play in isolated areas most often	chose busy group areas most often	

Initiating Interaction

approached a peer and offered a toy	approached a peer and said '____'	tapped a peer on the shoulder to get attention
made eye contact and smiled at a peer	entered a peer's play by adding a block	invited a peer to play by saying '____'
initiated physical play (running, chasing)	did not initiate interactions during the observation	initiated ____ interactions during ____ minutes

Responding to Peer Interaction

smiled when a peer approached	accepted the toy offered by a peer	declined the toy and turned away
responded to peer's question with words	responded to peer's question with gestures	ignored peer initiations during the observation
moved away when a peer spoke to them	played alongside peer for ____ minutes after initial contact	joined peer play and sustained it for ____

Conflict & Repair with Peers

pushed a peer when ____ occurred	took a toy without asking	said 'stop' or 'no' to a peer
waited for a peer to finish before taking a turn	asked 'can I have a turn?' with verbal prompting	attempted to trade materials with a peer
walked away from conflict without escalating	accepted adult mediation during conflict	returned to play with the peer within ____
apologized verbally or with a gesture		

10. Adult Interaction & Response

Terms for documenting the child's relationship and response to adults.

Describe the child's specific response to adult interaction — not your interpretation of the relationship quality.

Seeking Adult Support		
approached the adult when ____	looked to the adult for reassurance before attempting	requested adult help by saying or gesturing ____
brought an object to show the adult	stood near the adult during ____	held adult's hand during transitions
asked adult to watch or participate	sought adult comfort after a conflict	

Responding to Adult Direction		
followed the direction immediately	followed the direction after ____ seconds	required a repeated direction ____ times
required a visual cue in addition to verbal direction	required physical proximity to follow through	responded positively to specific adult by name
responded differently to different adults	followed direction from a preferred adult	complied after a choice was offered
complied after a visual schedule was used		

Adult Scaffolding That Helped		
completed task with hand-over-hand support	completed task with verbal step-by-step guidance	completed task with adult seated beside them
completed task with a visual model	completed task after adult demonstrated once	responded well to a calm, quiet voice
responded well to a specific praise phrase	needed fewer prompts when given extra time	succeeded when the task was broken into smaller steps
succeeded when the environment was quieter		

11. Emotional Expression

Observable, positively framed language for documenting how children express a range of emotions.

All emotions are valid. Document the observable signs of emotion without labeling the child as 'dramatic,' 'moody,' 'oversensitive,' or 'a crier.' Describe what you see and hear.

Signs of Joy & Excitement		
smiled broadly	laughed aloud	clapped hands
jumped up and down	ran with arms out	said '___' with a raised voice
sought eye contact while laughing	giggled repeatedly during ___	expressed enthusiasm by ___
shared the moment with a peer or adult		

Signs of Frustration or Upset		
cried for ___ minutes	whimpered	said 'no' repeatedly
pushed materials away	walked away from the activity	lay on the floor without moving
covered face with hands	stomped feet	slammed materials on the table
said '___' (exact words used)	made a sound described as ___	required ___ minutes before re-engaging

Signs of Calm & Contentment		
engaged quietly with materials for ___ minutes	hummed or sang quietly to themselves	smiled occasionally during the activity
sat relaxed with open body posture	responded to conversation in a measured tone	worked steadily without visible distress
appeared focused and at ease		

Signs of Worry or Uncertainty		
stood at the edge of the group before joining	watched the activity for ___ minutes before participating	looked toward the door at drop-off for ___ minutes
asked 'where is my mom/dad?' ___ times	clung to adult at transition	held a comfort object throughout ___
needed adult reassurance before attempting new task	hesitated before entering a new space	covered mouth or twisted clothing during ___

Signs of Pride & Confidence		
held up work and said 'look'	smiled and repeated the action after succeeding	said 'I did it!'
sought adult acknowledgment after completing task	tried again after an initial unsuccessful attempt	showed work to a peer
independently selected a challenge-level task		

12. Strengths & Positive Descriptors

Use these words and phrases to lead with what the child does well.

Every observation and every family conversation should begin with the child's strengths. These terms describe genuine, observable capacities — not hollow praise.

Character & Approach to Learning

curious	persistent	creative
imaginative	detail-oriented	methodical
inventive	enthusiastic about learning	loves to explore
asks thoughtful questions	observant	remembers details others miss
approaches new materials with openness	tries new things when supported	keeps trying after mistakes

Social Strengths

warm and affectionate with familiar adults	shows genuine care for peers	notices when others are sad
shares materials when prompted	shares materials spontaneously	includes peers in play
greet others warmly	is sought out by peers as a play partner	makes peers laugh
advocates for themselves verbally	expresses preferences clearly	

Communication Strengths

communicates needs clearly	rich vocabulary for age	tells detailed stories
asks relevant questions	listens attentively during read-aloud	remembers and retells story details
uses humor and playfulness in language	explains their thinking step by step	communicates through multiple modes
makes their needs known clearly		

Physical & Creative Strengths

strong gross motor skills	excellent balance and coordination	precise fine motor control
talented builder and engineer	expressive and creative in art	musical — responds to rhythm and beat
physically energetic and healthy	strong spatial awareness	excellent at puzzles and patterns
uses body to express ideas expressively		

Self-Awareness & Regulation Strengths		
knows own feelings and names them	asks for what they need	takes breaks independently
uses the calm-down corner effectively	accepts redirection gracefully	bounces back quickly from disappointment
comfortable asking for help	reads the room and adjusts	responds well to routine and predictability
flexible when supports are in place		

13. Strategies & Supports

Terms for documenting what supports were tried and how the child responded.

Document not just what the child did, but what you tried and what made a difference. This is essential information for referrals, family conversations, and team planning.

Environmental Modifications		
reduced visual clutter in work area	offered preferential seating near the adult	provided a quiet workspace
used flexible seating (wobble cushion, floor space)	used natural lighting when possible	reduced background noise during instruction
offered a visual schedule for the routine	posted visual supports at child's eye level	used a first-then visual board
provided a designated calm-down space	offered a transition object	used sensory tools in the environment (fidget, weighted blanket)

Instructional Supports		
broke task into smaller steps	provided a visual model before asking child to try	offered a step-by-step picture guide
used hand-over-hand support	provided wait time before expecting a response	gave one direction at a time
used simple, direct language	repeated directions using the same words	offered choice within the activity
used a timer to signal transitions	provided a 5-minute and 2-minute warning before transitions	used a peer buddy model
incorporated the child's interests into the task		

Relational & Co-Regulation Supports		
adult sat beside child during difficult moment	adult used a calm, quiet voice	adult named the child's feeling aloud
adult offered two choices	adult used a warm and predictable greeting	adult reduced demands during distress
adult provided physical reassurance (if welcomed)	adult used humor to de-escalate	adult narrated the plan ('First we will...')
adult provided genuine specific praise		

Movement & Sensory Supports		
offered a movement break before the task	incorporated movement into the learning activity	provided a sensory bin as a calming option
offered deep pressure activities before demanding tasks	used weighted lap pad	offered resistance band on chair legs
provided proprioceptive input through obstacle course	offered headphones or earmuffs during loud activities	allowed child to use gloves or tools with messy materials
offered alternatives to messy materials		

14. Documentation Phrases & Sentence Starters

Ready-to-use professional language for writing objective observation notes.

Copy or adapt these sentence starters directly into your observation notes. Fill in the bracketed information with specific, accurate details.

Opening an Observation Note	
During [activity/routine] on [date], [child's initials] ____	Over the past [X days/weeks], staff have observed that ____
On [date] at [time] during [activity], the following was observed: ____	This observation was recorded by [initials] on [date] at [time] in [location]. ____
During a [X-minute] observation of [routine], [child's initials] ____	

Describing Frequency & Duration	
This occurred ____ times during the ____ minute observation.	The behavior lasted approximately ____ minutes each time.
Staff have observed this pattern on ____ out of the past ____ school days.	This was the ____ time this week this occurred during [routine].
The child remained [in this state] for approximately ____ minutes before ____	Staff documented ____ separate incidents between [date] and [date].

Describing What Helped	
The child calmed within ____ minutes when ____	The child completed the task after [support] was provided.
When given [strategy], the child [response].	The child responded well to [adult] using a [calm/quiet/warm] voice.
With a visual schedule in place, the child [response].	When offered a choice between ____ and ____, the child ____
After a [X-minute] movement break, the child ____	

Describing What Did Not Help	
Verbal redirection alone did not result in ____	The child did not respond to [strategy] on this occasion.
Repeated verbal prompting did not change the behavior.	The behavior continued despite [support tried].
The child's distress did not decrease when [approach] was used.	

Closing an Observation Note	
Follow-up: [action planned]	This observation will be shared with [family/team] on [date].
Pattern has been noted across [X] observations. Referral is being considered.	Staff will continue to document this pattern and review on [date].
This note has been reviewed by [supervisor initials] on [date].	Observation documented by [initials]. Record stored in [location].

A note on professional responsibility: These word banks are a starting point, not a shortcut. The best documentation is specific, accurate, and grounded in direct observation. Before sharing any observation with a family, re-read it and ask: Does this describe what I actually saw and heard? Does it treat this child and family with dignity? Could I stand behind this professionally? If the answer to all three is yes — it's ready to share.